

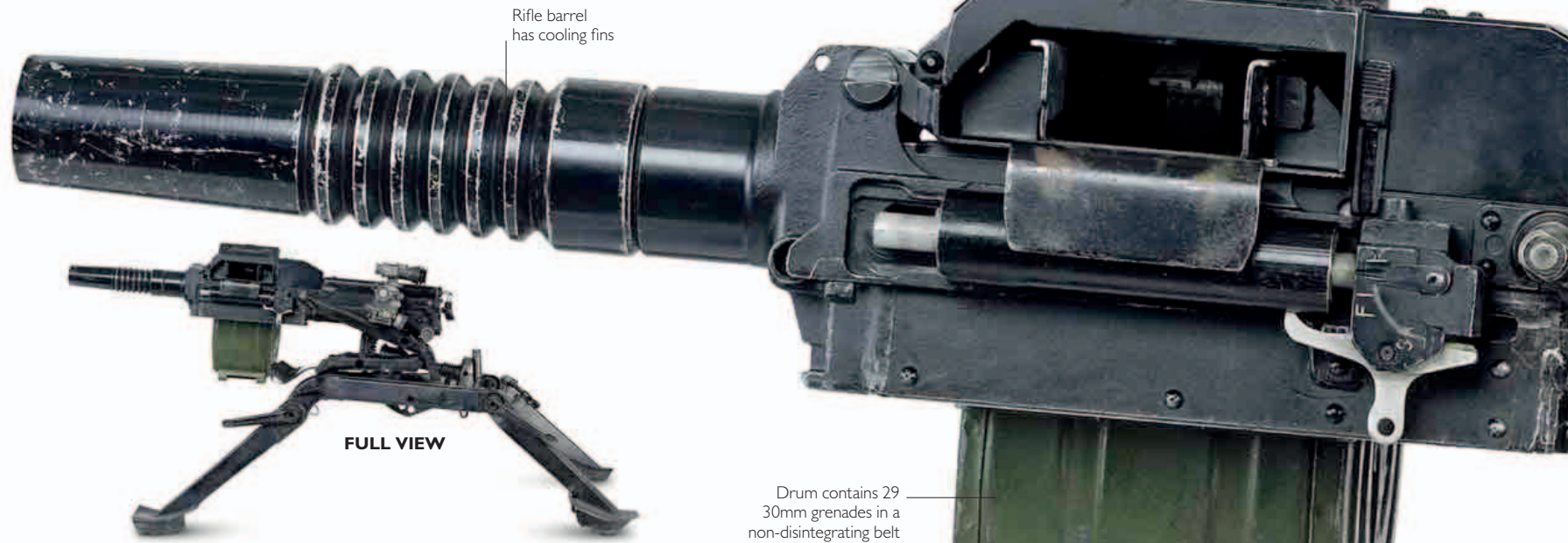
GRENADE-LAUNCHERS

The highly fluid character of modern warfare has necessitated mortars that are portable or even handheld infantry weapons. More often termed grenade-launchers, these mortars are designed to provide immediate support fire. The simplest are the American M79 and the South African Mechem. In contrast, the Russian AGS-17 almost enters the artillery class with its heavy fixed mount. The Rocket Propelled Grenade (RPG) launcher is now the most common launcher due to its simplicity and effectiveness. Its shaped-charge projectiles allow a single combatant to disable or destroy armored vehicles and fixed positions such as buildings.



▲ M79 “BLOOPER”
Date 1961
Origin US
Barrel 12in (30.5cm)
Caliber 40mm
Grenade range 328 yards (300m)

Nicknamed the “Blooper” because of the distinctive sound it makes when fired, the M79 grenade-launcher bridged the gap between short-range hand grenades and the long-range mortar. In addition to firing high-explosive grenades, the M79 could fire antipersonnel, smoke, and illuminating rounds. During the Vietnam War, two M79s were issued to each US infantry squad consisting of nine men.



▼ RPG-7V
Date 1961
Origin Soviet Union
Barrel 37½in (95cm)
Caliber 40mm
Grenade range 547 yards (500m)

The RPG-7V can be used with a variety of grenades, including antipersonnel, fuel-air explosive, and high-explosive antitank ones. Regardless of the grenade type, the projectiles have two propelling charges, one for launching and the other for flight.

